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The Problem

Our organization's client-facing Online Help documentation workflow relies heavily on **MadCap Flare**, which introduces several challenges that hinder efficiency, scalability, and maintainability:

1. **Complex and Clunky Authoring Environment**
   Flare's interface is highly specialized and non-intuitive, requiring significant training and ongoing support. Simple tasks—such as styling content or managing images—often involve multiple steps and proprietary settings. This slows down authoring and often requires time-consuming troubleshooting.

2. **Manual and Time-Consuming Publication Process**
   Publishing content in Flare involves configuring targets, managing conditional tags, and generating outputs manually. This process is error-prone and lacks automation, making it difficult to maintain consistent builds across multiple outputs (HTML5, PDF, etc.). Any small change can require a full rebuild, adding unnecessary overhead.

3. **Preview Limitations and Version Control Risks**
   MadCap Flare requires you to save the entire project before generating a preview of a topic or change. Once you save the project to see a preview, there's no built-in mechanism to roll back to the previous version unless you manually restore from a backup or external version control system. If the preview doesn't look right, you're stuck with the saved state, adding unnecessary risk and cleanup work.

4. **Poor Developer Experience**
   Flare is not accessible to developers. This creates a silo between the writing and development teams as developers aren't able to leave inline comments, suggest changes, or approve edits as part of a modern DevOps workflow. Instead, comments and collaboration for Flare materials must occur outside the tool, which is inefficient and time consuming.

5. **No Native Integration with CI/CD Pipelines**
   Flare cannot integrate natively with **Azure DevOps Pipelines** or other CI/CD systems. Automating builds and deployments requires complex workarounds or manual intervention. In contrast, Markdown-based tools like **DocFX** integrate

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seamlessly with Azure Pipelines, enabling automated builds, previews, and deployments as part of a modern DevOps workflow.

6. **Vendor Lock-In**
   Proprietary formats tie us to Flare's ecosystem. If licensing costs rise or the product roadmap changes, we have limited flexibility to pivot quickly without significant effort.

   Note: One of our MadCap Flare licenses is a perpetual license that MadCap no longer provides. If they decide to phase out legacy licensing, we are susceptible to more expensive subscription pricing.

The Proposed Solution

To overcome the limitations of MadCap Flare, we propose transitioning to **DocFX**, an open-source, **Markdown-based** documentation platform. This tool aligns with modern development practices and offers significant advantages, such as:

1. **Seamless Integration with CI/CD Pipelines**
   Unlike Flare, DocFX integrates natively with **Azure DevOps Pipelines** and other CI/CD systems. This enables automated builds, previews, and deployments, reducing manual effort and ensuring consistent output across environments.

2. **Lightweight, Developer-Friendly Authoring**
   Markdown is simple, intuitive, and widely adopted. Developers and writers can collaborate in the same workflow using familiar tools like VS Code and Git, eliminating the steep learning curve associated with Flare's proprietary interface.

3. **Instant Local Previews Without Risk**
   DocFX allows authors to preview changes locally without committing or saving to the main branch. This prevents accidental overwrites and supports rapid iteration, unlike Flare's requirement to save before previewing.

4. **Open Standards and Portability**
   Markdown and HTML are open formats, ensuring future-proof content that can be migrated easily to other platforms. This eliminates vendor lock-in and reduces long-term risk.

5. **Improved Collaboration and Version Control**
   Documentation lives in a Git repository, enabling pull requests, inline comments, and code reviews.

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6. **Automation and Scalability**
   With DocFX, we can leverage existing DevOps practices—such as automated testing, linting, and deployment—to scale documentation efficiently across multiple outputs without manual intervention.

DocFX

DocFX is an open-source documentation generator widely used in .NET ecosystems but flexible enough for general technical documentation. Its advantages include:

- **Markdown-Based Authoring**
  Supports Markdown and YAML, making content easy to write, maintain, and review in Git-based workflows.
- **Strong Integration with Developer Tools**
  Designed for developer-centric environments, DocFX integrates well with Visual Studio and Azure DevOps, enabling automated documentation builds as part of the development pipeline.
- **Static Site Generation**
  Produces fast, lightweight static sites that can be hosted anywhere, including Azure Static Web Apps or GitHub Pages.
- **API Documentation Support**
  Ideal for projects that need API references, as DocFX can generate documentation directly from source code comments.
- **Customizable Themes and Templates**
  Allows branding and layout customization without complex proprietary systems.

Comparison Analysis

Feature	MadCap Flare	DocFX
Cost	$4,510/year (for 2 subscriptions)	Free (open-source)
Authoring Format	Proprietary XML-based	Markdown + YAML
Ease of Use	Steep learning curve	Simple, developer-friendly
Preview Workflow	Requires saving project	Instant local preview (no commit)
Version Control Integration	Limited, complex with Git	Native Git integration

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CI/CD Integration	No native support	Full support (Azure Pipelines, GitHub)
Collaboration	Difficult for developers	Easy via pull request and comments
Vendor Lock-In	High (proprietary formats)	None (open standards)
Customization	Limited, proprietary templates	Customizable theme and templates
API Documentation	Manual setup	Strong support (auto-generate from code)
Hosting	Built-in (with license)	GitHub Pages, Azure Static Web Apps

Security Considerations

1. **Current State (MadCap Flare)**
    - Flare stores content locally in proprietary formats. Security depends on workstation and network controls, but there is limited transparency into how files are handled internally.
    - There is no built-in encryption for sensitive content; protection relies entirely on our IT environment.
2. **Markdown-Based Tool (DocFX)**
    - DocFX uses plain text files stored in Git repositories. While this improves collaboration, it also means security is determined by repository and hosting configurations.
3. **Advantages Over Flare**
    - DocFX allows full transparency and auditing of code for security vulnerabilities.
    - Integration with enterprise security policies (e.g., Azure DevOps, GitHub Enterprise) ensures compliance and centralized control.
    - Automated CI/CD pipelines can include security scans and linting to prevent accidental exposure of sensitive data.

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Risks & Mitigation

1. **Migration Complexity**
    - **Risk**: Converting Flare's proprietary formats to Markdown may result in broken links, lost metadata, or inconsistent styling.
    - **Mitigation**:
        - Use automated conversion tools where possible, followed by manual quality assurance.
        - Create a migration checklist for link validation, image handling, and metadata preservation.
        - Pilot migration with a small content set before full rollout.
3. **Training and Adoption**
    - **Risk**: Teammates unfamiliar with Git workflows or Markdown may face a learning curve.
    - **Mitigation**:
        - Provide hands-on training sessions and quick-start guides.
        - Assign internal champions to support adoption.
        - Use visual editors (e.g., VS Code extensions) to ease Markdown editing.
        - Leverage web-based resources for training, such as LinkedIn Learn courses.
4. **Operational Disruption**
    - **Risk**: Delays in publishing during the transition period.
    - **Mitigation**:
        - Maintain parallel publishing in Flare until the new system is stable.
        - Define clear rollback procedures in case of critical issues.

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Impact to Business

Transitioning from MadCap Flare to DocFX is a complex re-platforming effort involving structural re-authoring, not just scriptable conversions. The effort to completely transfer all Help documentation to DocFX is estimated to take 12-18 months on the basis of two Technical Writers allotting two hours a business day on the project. As such, we would need to maintain our current MadCap licenses for that duration to maintain existing documentation workflows.

The transition entails the following tasks:

1. **Inventory and Assessment**
    a. For each of our MadCap Flare projects, we must collect and record the following:
        i. Topic counts
        ii. Snippets usage
        iii. Conditions/variables (Flare's conditional text)
        iv. TOCs
        v. Reused content patterns
        vi. Build targets (How many outputs exist)
        vii. HTML5 skin customizations
2. **Export Content from MadCap Flare**
    a. Build each project to clean HTML5 (no search or skin features).
    b. Export raw XHTML topics from Content Explorer.
    c. Create a flattened export folder with:
        i. `/content` (HTML)
        ii. `/snippets` (flats)
        iii. `/resources` (images, PDFs, CSS)
3. **Convert HTML to Markdown**

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   a. Use Pandoc, HTML→Markdown scripts, or Custom regex cleanup to do the following:
      i. Convert XHTML → Markdown
      ii. Strip Flare classes and spans
      iii. Convert inline styles to clean Markdown
      iv. Ensure image paths resolve
      v. Remove build-only elements like proxy, MadCap variables, and MadCap conditions

4. **Rebuild TOC Structures**
   a. Convert the Table of Contents in MadCap Flare to DocFX YAML Table of Contents.

5. **Assets & Media Cleanup**
   a. Move images into an **/images/project_name/** folder
   b. Update all image references in Markdown
   c. Remove unused images and PDFs
   d. Normalize naming conventions
   e. Build a Snippet library in Markdown to replace Flare Snippets
   f. Build an Image library in Markdown

6. **Build a DocFX Project Structure**
   a. Create a master docfx.json folder containing:
      i. Inputs
      ii. Output config
      iii. Theme selection
      iv. Global metadata
      v. Search config

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7. **Apply Branding and Theming**
    a. Choose DocFX theme (default or custom)
    b. Apply our organization's branding
    c. Make CSS adjustments where necessary
    d. Apply search customizations
8. **Quality Review & Link Checks**
    a. Validate all internal links
    b. Fix broken anchors from Flare to Markdown
    c. Spellcheck
    d. Format consistency
    e. Ensure code blocks, tables, and notes render correctly
9. **Publishing Pipeline Setup**
    a. Build script (docfx build)
    b. Azure Blob upload script (GitHub actions)
    c. Integration with Tech Team's current processes
    d. Git-based docs repository
    e. PR workflow for updates

Summary

Transitioning from MadCap Flare to DocFX represents a strategic modernization of our organization's documentation ecosystem—one that reduces long-term costs, streamlines operations, and aligns our authoring workflows with the tools and practices already used throughout the organization. By moving to a Markdown-based, Git-driven platform, Generic Company Incorporated gains a documentation process that is faster, more flexible, and inherently more collaborative.

DocFX eliminates the limitations of Flare's proprietary environment by enabling automation, continuous integration, and seamless deployment through Azure DevOps Pipelines. This shift not only accelerates publishing cycles but also improves reliability by

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removing the manual, error-prone steps required in the current workflow. Writers and developers can work in the same ecosystem, using familiar tools such as VS Code and Git, resulting in better cross-team collaboration, improved review processes, and reduced operational friction.

In addition, DocFX's foundation on open standards offers long-term stability and portability. Content authored in Markdown and YAML can be easily repurposed, migrated, or integrated into future systems without vendor lock-in. Security and transparency are also enhanced, as documentation resides in controlled repositories with full audit trails, automated checks, and configurable access policies.

While the transition requires a large upfront work effort—including inventorying existing Flare projects, converting content, rebuilding structure, and designing a new theme—it creates a sustainable, scalable documentation platform that supports our future growth. Maintaining Flare during this migration ensures continuity, while the phased approach minimizes disruption.

Ultimately, moving to DocFX positions us to deliver documentation that is more maintainable, more consistent, and better aligned with modern engineering practices—ensuring higher efficiency, improved quality, and reduced total cost of ownership in the years ahead.

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